



PHOTO BY **SANDESH RAVIKUMAR**

EYES ON THE PRIZE Irfan Razack,
Chairman & MD, Prestige Estates Projects

Key Highlights

❶ Under Razack, Prestige saw higher sales in the past two years of the pandemic than pre-Covid-19 times

❷ Spotted the opportunity early—sold off retail and hotel assets at the right valuation to Blackstone and focussed on developing newer projects

❸ Razack's ability to see an opportunity at under-valued locations and efficient execution boosted fortunes

❹ Aggressive bets in larger markets like Mumbai and NCR, and 43 million sq. ft upcoming office and retail portfolio to boost rental income 10x

❺ Launch of \$500-million fund to fuel land acquisitions

| 111

aspects of the business, design innovations, and his futuristic, non-confrontational approach.

Balakrishna Hegde, Founder and Managing Director of Chartered Housing Private Limited, has known Razack for years. What impresses Hegde is how Razack has managed to chart his own path. "He is a lion. Which ever path he treads on, it turns into a highway. If he sets his eyes on to something, he gets it," says Hegde. The group's fortunes ride on Razack's uncanny ability to visualise business prospects of a site that may appear mundane to others. "His gut and his tremendous courage are Razack's real strengths," Hedge adds.

The man himself is dismissive about his contributions. "During the first set of lockdowns in 2020, it was very important to ensure that the construction workers were taken care of so that even if they went back to their homes, they came back as soon as the situation normalised. And similarly, vaccinating and arranging healthcare benefits last year was the priority. These things gave them the

confidence that the management is keen on taking care of them and this has been the key behind Prestige's ability to minimise disruptions," says Razack.

By December 2020, Prestige's business had made a turnaround with strong sales and gross bookings, according to an analysis by HDFC Securities. The company managed to grow sales by 55 per cent year-on-year and with over 3 million sq. ft of gross bookings—85 per cent higher YoY—Prestige was already outperforming its peers.

M.V. Satish, Whole-time Director and Senior Executive VP at L&T—which has awarded one of its largest projects, a 6,000-unit-plus residential project in Mumbai's Malad, to Prestige—says what is striking about Razack is his transparency in dealing with the stakeholders of any project and his humbleness. "After all, you don't expect somebody like Razack to sit with a small-time plot owner and sort out whatever issues he may have," he says. **BT**

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